PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #53 · PTSD

“What happened was my fault. I should have seen it coming and stopped it.”

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Where it often comes from

People who were hurt often search for a reason they could have controlled. “If it was my fault, then I can make sure it never happens again.” That search feels like safety. It is usually a lie that piles shame on top of harm. You did not have to see it coming. You did not have to stop what someone else chose, or what you had no power to prevent. A counselor can help you lay down a blame that was never yours, without forcing the details. A counselor can help you work with this at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do it alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

There is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus. The Lord has compassion and knows our frame. He is near the brokenhearted. He binds up the brokenhearted and proclaims liberty. Jesus tells His friends not to let their hearts be troubled. None of these verses say that suffering is proof you caused it. Self-blame can feel responsible. It is not the same thing as truth, and it is not what God asks of a wounded person.

> *“Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus”* (Romans 8:1).

Also see

> “As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust” (Psalm 103:13–14).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “The Spirit of the Lord GOD is on Me, because the LORD has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and freedom to the prisoners” (Isaiah 61:1).

> “Peace I leave with you; My peace I give to you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled; do not be afraid” (John 14:27).

Common self-statements

- I should have known.
- If I had been smarter, braver, or quieter, it would not have happened.
- A good person would have stopped it.
- God must think it was my fault too.
- I do not deserve comfort.
- If I blame myself, at least the world makes sense.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Taking blame for what another person did, or for what you could not control.
- Hindsight bias: Judging your past self with information you did not have then.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding you are guilty.
- All-or-nothing thinking: If you did not prevent it perfectly, it was entirely your fault.

Challenging questions

- What, exactly, do I believe I should have done, and could I really have done it then?
- Whose choice was it, if I set my self-blame aside?
- Would I blame a friend who lived through the same thing?
- Am I using blame to feel less helpless?
- What does "no condemnation" mean for a person who was hurt?
- What would my counselor want me to stop saying to myself?

Truth summary

> What happened was not mine to stop just because I wish I had. I am not condemned, and I do not have to carry blame that is not mine.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Thinking, Healthy
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Forgiveness
- Depression, Symptoms of

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Suffering
- Self-Esteem, Low

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
The voice that says it was all your fault is not the voice of truth.

East to West — Casting Crowns
God does not measure you by a blame you were never meant to carry.

Hello My Name Is — Matthew West
God names you as His, not as the cause of what was done.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
Grace meets you here. You do not have to finish the story by blaming yourself.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

My Plan for Replacing "What happened was my fault. I should have seen it coming and stopped it."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"What happened was my fault. I should have seen it coming and stopped it." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What, exactly, do I believe I should have done, and could I really have done it then?
- ☐ Whose choice was it, if I set my self-blame aside?
- ☐ Would I blame a friend who lived through the same thing?
- ☐ Am I using blame to feel less helpless?
- ☐ What does "no condemnation" mean for a person who was hurt?
- ☐ What would my counselor want me to stop saying to myself?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ What happened was not mine to stop just because I wish I had. I am not condemned, and I do not have to carry blame that is not mine.
- ☐ Wanting to have stopped it does not mean I caused it.
- ☐ I can grieve without putting myself on trial.
- ☐ God does not condemn me for what I could not prevent.
- ☐ Shame is not the same thing as guilt.
- ☐ I can tell the truth about responsibility with a counselor, slowly.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ Psalm 103:13–14
  "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."

A verse I found myself:

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ When you put yourself on trial: Each day, write down one moment when you blamed yourself for what happened. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 8:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I wish I had stopped it. That wish is not a conviction. In Christ I am not condemned.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- ☐ Write the charge, then the facts. One sentence of self-blame. Then one sentence a fair friend would say. Do not add graphic detail.
- ☐ Ask your counselor to help you sort real responsibility from blame that is not yours. Stop if it becomes too much.
- ☐ Refuse one "I should have." When the sentence starts, say, "I did not have to see it coming," and stop.
- ☐ Read Romans 8:1 each morning before you review the past.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "What happened was my fault. I should have seen it coming and stopped it.": _____ %

My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment I did not take the blame
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~What happened was my fault. I should have seen it coming and stopped it~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have put myself on trial for something I could not carry. There is no condemnation in Christ. Teach me the difference between grief and guilt, and give me a counselor's help as I lay this down. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.